

DOGS



DOGS HAVE LIVED with people for more than 12,000 years. They may have started to stay near humans for food and warmth. Then people began to train dogs to work for them. They bred certain types of dog for herding and guarding other domestic animals, then for hunting and for companionship. Gradually, different types of dog developed, but it was not until the end of the 19th century that specific breeds were classified. Today, there are about 200 dog breeds throughout the world. They are more varied in their appearance and behaviour than any other domestic animal.



Siberian husky



English setter



Shetland sheepdogs



Chihuahua



Scottish terriers



Bloodhound

Dog groups

The people of ancient Egypt and western Asia were the first to breed distinct types of dog for different purposes. By Roman times, dogs were kept for much the same reasons as they are today. There are six main groups – (from left to right) top row: working, sporting, herding; bottom row: companion, terriers, and hounds.

Domestic dogs

All breeds of domestic dog, from the Great Dane to the chihuahua, are descended from the wolf and have inherited the wolf's instincts. Like wolves, dogs are pack animals. They treat humans as part of their pack, and can be trained to accept their owner as the pack leader, and to follow his or her commands.



Borzois have sharp eyesight and hunt by sight.

The borzoi was bred in Russia in the 13th century and used first to hunt wolves.

Long, strong legs and a flexible body for speed

Dog features

The wolf is designed to chase, capture, kill, and eat its prey. It is agile, with strong legs for running long distances. Domestic dogs retain many of the features of a wolf, but through selective breeding now exist in many shapes, sizes, and colours.

Coats

There are three main types of dog coats – long, short, and wiry. Most breeds have an outer coat of guard hairs and an undercoat of shorter hairs. They moult, or shed their fur, changing their coat in spring and autumn.



Short hair



Long hair



Wire hair

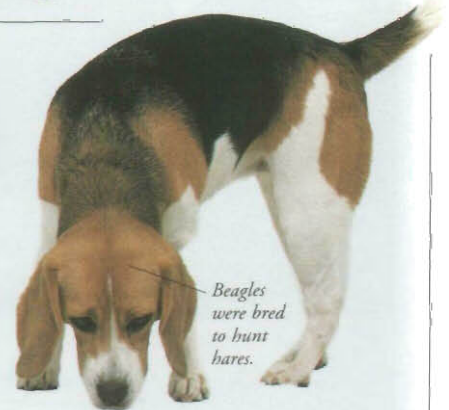
Feet

Dogs walk on their toes rather than the soles of their feet. Their paw pads help with grip, as do their claws, which are non-retractable.



Senses

Dogs have highly developed senses of hearing and smell. They use these in communication and to track down their prey. The police use dogs to sniff out explosives, criminals, and drugs. The dogs can see well in the dark and are good at seeing movement in the distance.



Beagles were bred to hunt hares.

Reproduction

A female dog is pregnant for about nine weeks, then gives birth to several puppies known as a litter. At birth, puppies are blind and deaf. Their eyes open at about 10 to 12 days old and they are able to hear at 13 to 17 days old. Teeth start to grow between three and five weeks of age.

A young puppy is defenceless.



All puppies are born with short legs and a little tail.



Eyes are fully open.



1 At one week old, a puppy spends most of its time sleeping and feeding by suckling from its mother.

2 At two weeks old, the puppy takes its first wobbling steps and begins to explore. Its eyes are now open and it can hear.

3 At three weeks old, the puppy may start to eat solid food. At first, its mother will regurgitate meat for it.

4 At six weeks old, the puppy no longer feeds from its mother. It can soon be taken away from her to a new home.

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